After Text Classification: Following Hikers Through an App Acquisition

Sizing pain points from over 250,000 hiking-app reviews

Rob Held

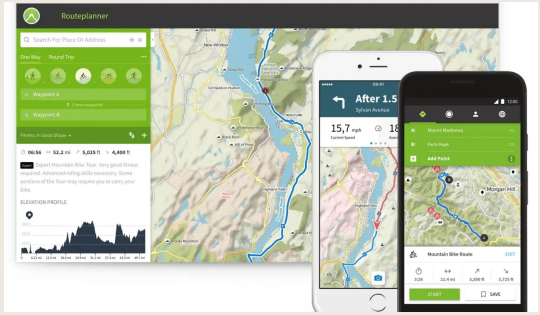
Customer Experience Analyst
Deutsche Glasfaser
Fan of Quant UXR since 2022
29. Oct. 2026



What happens when...

the app you rely on for exploring new places, tracking your endurance or sharing your activity with a like-minded community gets acquired by a tech conglomerate?

This is the story of komoot and Bending Spoons



komoot

Berlin area, Germany

#1 in DACH for route planning and navigation

45M users



Bending Spoons

Milan, Italy

“buy, consolidate and long-term operate”

komoot (2025), Evernote, Vimeo, Eventbrite and most recently Airtable; now acquiring Miro

Sources: komoot and Bending Spoons Wikipedia pages

Methods behind the scenes:

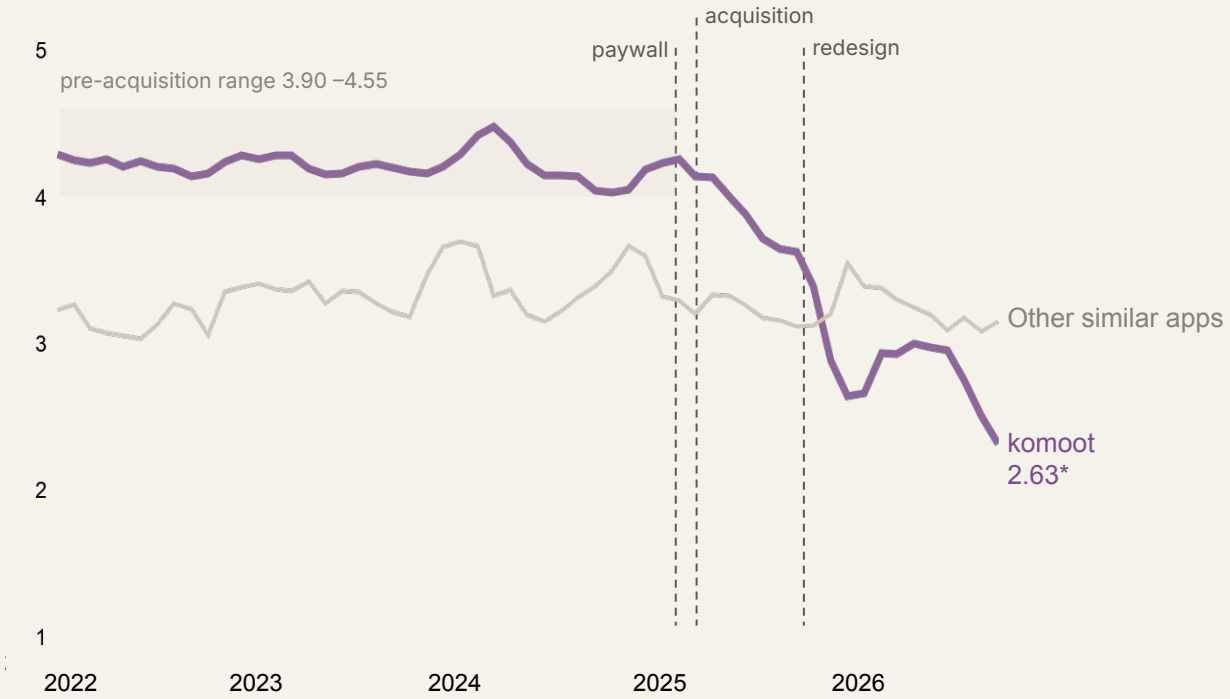
Last year's talk: Text Classification

- **Unstructured text:** open-ended surveys, reviews, transcripts
- **Thematic analysis:** codebook with rules and examples
- **Text Classifier:** detecting text themes, selecting the right tool for job

This year: Sizing

- **Extract** impactful pain points from reviews to include in a survey for comparison
- **Multiple Choice** to assess relevance of pain points
- **MaxDiff** to force trade offs to identify most urgent pains
- **Contextual items** to enrich the dataset and learn about user segments, purchase, churn intent, competitor use

Since 2025, komoot app store ratings are in free-fall



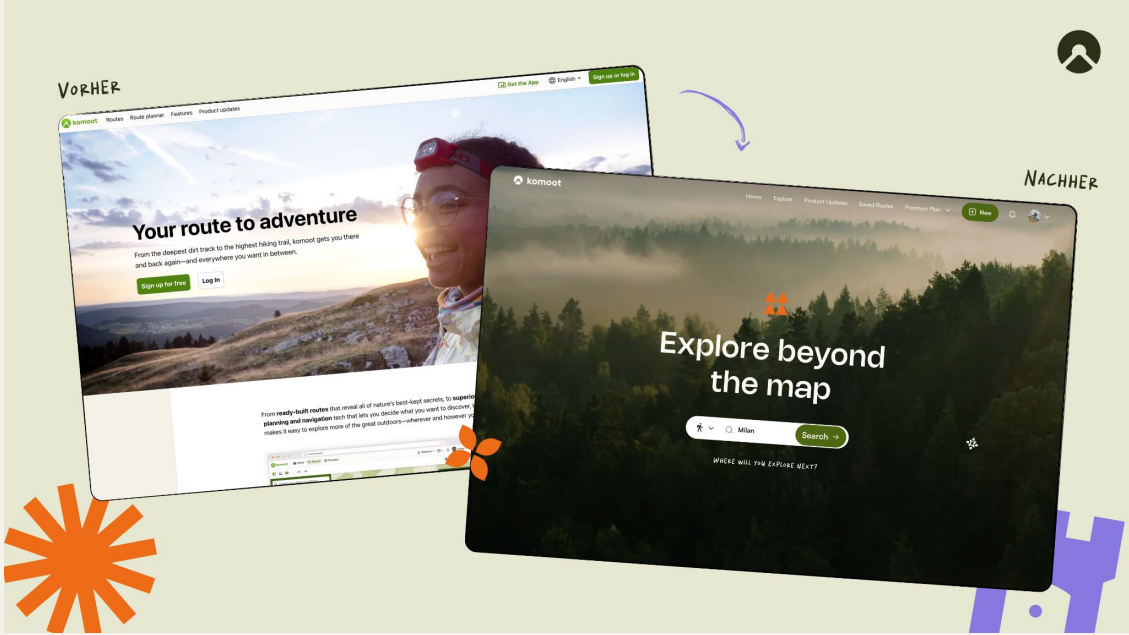
42% rating loss, so far

Consistently above category benchmark years prior to acquisition,

komoot DACH ratings sit below the average rating of direct competitors and trending downwards

komoot · DACH Play Store, App Store· monthly mean · Jan 2022 – Sep 2026 · n = 68,000 · *September 2026 average rating, n = 1,936

At the same time, komoot published reports focusing on user preference for the product's redesign in 2025



"80%

Of the surveyed users prefer the new design..."

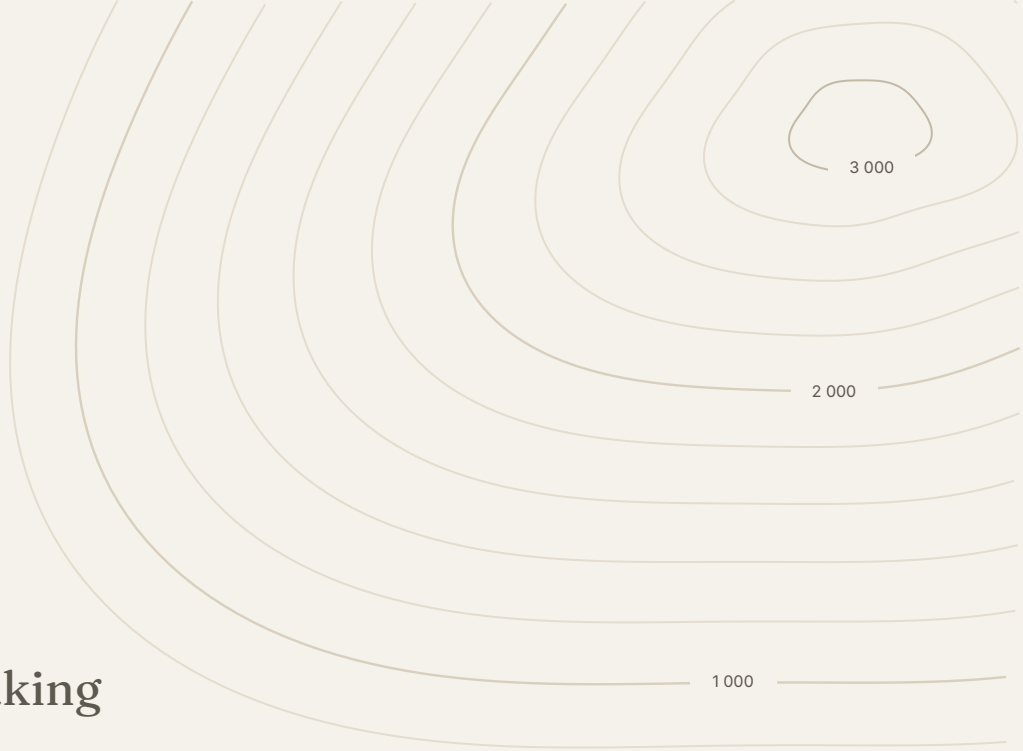
komoot user survey, n = 3,000

komoot redesign: komoot Newsroom, 18.10.26

PART 2 · REVIEW TEXT

Explore

Classified text to tell us what is breaking



Sifting through ratings & reviews for reliable signals

What

a. **Ratings & reviews** from app stores
- corpus of 285k reviews from outdoor navigation and route planning category in major markets
- 67k reviews from DACH
- 28,523 only from komoot users in DACH region

b. **Thematic Analysis**: LLM-assisted creation of a codebook of rules and examples of mutually exclusive themes in komoot reviews

c. **Holdout**: hand-coded reviews withheld from training, used for testing classifier performance.

d. **Text Classifier**: multi-label tagging of unseen reviews

e. **Impact & Evolution:** measure theme impact on rating and tracking changes in share of mentions over time

How

Secondary data collection, classification and analysis conducted with Python in Jupyter

Program building; thematic analysis and codebook building from 3k rows for €15.28

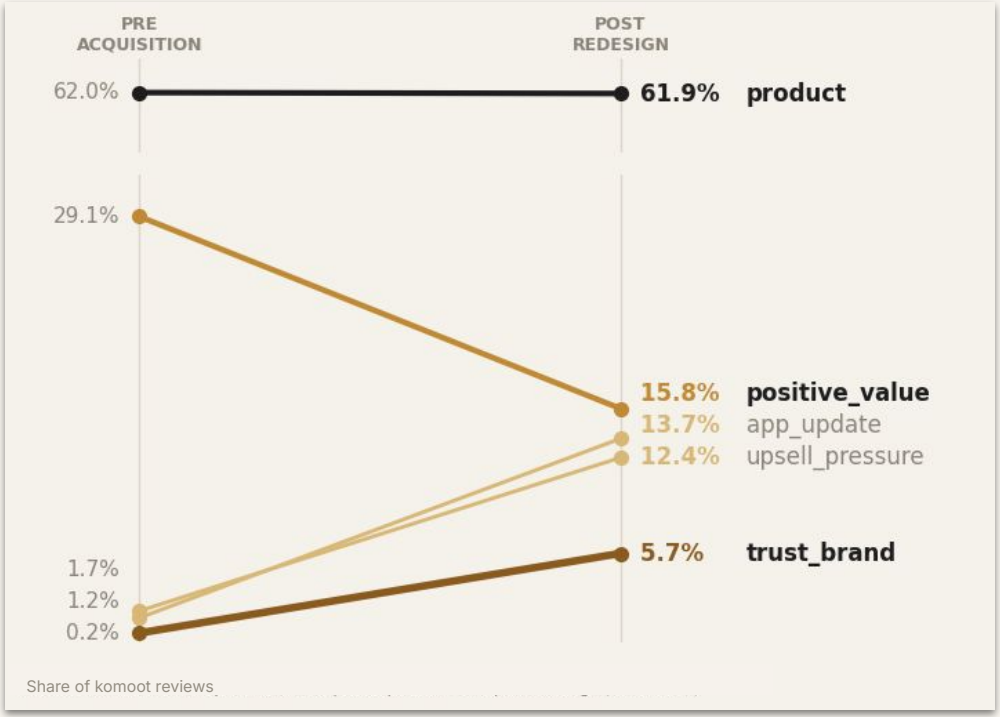
Performance: switch from LLMs to ngrams + linear SVM to scale the classification of reviews



Impact: the effect theme has on overall star rating

Pain Point defined as a theme with negative impact on ratings or a change in its share mentions post acquisition

komoot's product-related feedback seems stable, yet the relationship is breaking in the reviews



trust_brand
0.2% → 5.7%

trust_brand speaks directly to change in the company, strategic decisions and communication with users

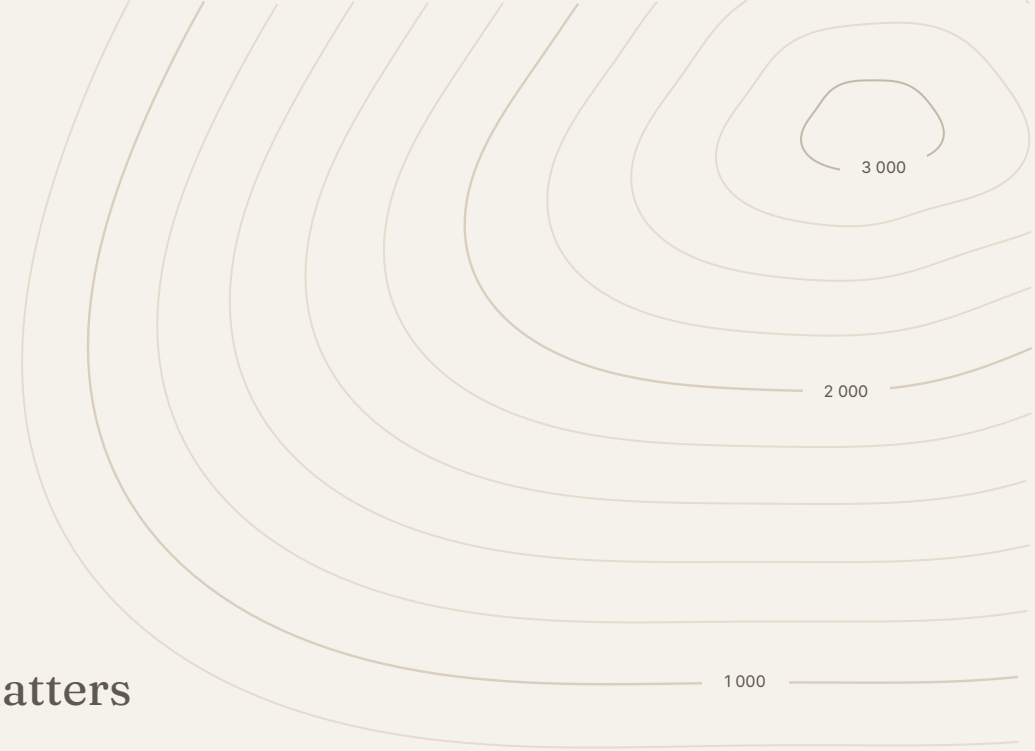
Sub-themes within Trust_brand:

a. acquisition_sentiment
b. team_loss
c. enshittification
d. communication

PART 3 · SURVEY

Size

Survey to tell us *how much* a pain matters when people have to choose.



Comparing extracted signals with komoot users

What

a. **Survey Design**: transferring and comparing urgent themes from secondary research
- Profile, outdoor activity
- Mock rating and review
- Pain point multiple choice,
- Forced trade offs between pain points
  - 20 items x 4 per screen x 15 screens
- Subscription, churn intent, competitor use

b. **Survey Testing**: ironing out the flow of questions with cognitive walkthrough, pilot before full launch

c. **Sample**: sourced with Prolific
- n = 150 komoot users, n = 50 of direct competitors
- German-native speakers
- 91% in DE, 56% on desktop, 51% Hikers, 31% once a month or less

How



LLM co-programmer for survey scripting



Survey built with Apps Script



Sample sourced with Prolific (may be less likely to have bots*)



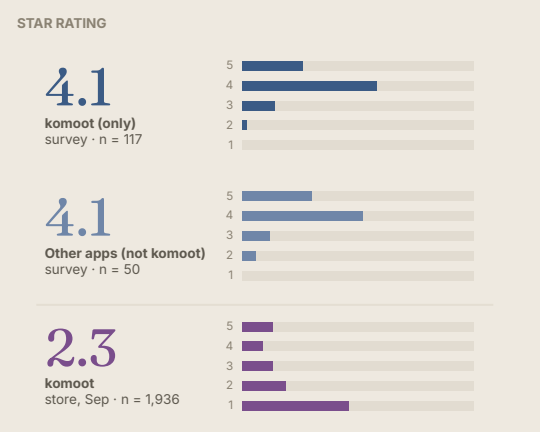
Netlify to host survey in testing phase to capture screen and audio recording



Google Sheets to monitor responses, partial and complete, for control during data collection

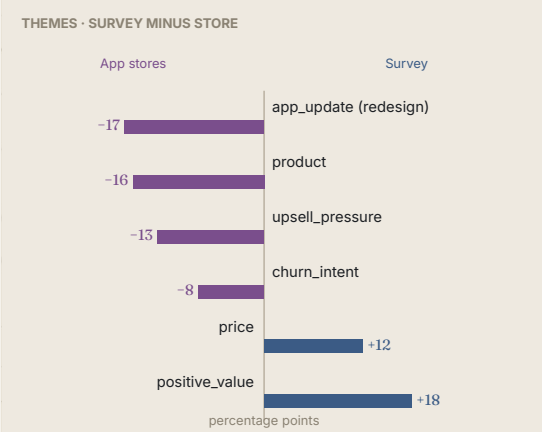
*Zhang et al 2026

How similar are the Secondary & Primary data?



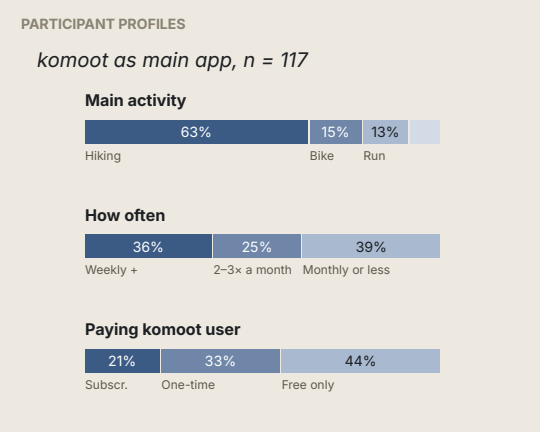
Unable to capture low ratings

Survey ratings in a mock app-store design are far more positive than online ratings in the same time period*



The acquisition pains are missing

Positive value is much more common in the survey mock reviews, with specific mentions of price instead of broad upsell pressure and churn intent



Paying users behind the feedback

Around 50% of the komoot feedback comes from self-reported paying users

Does it look the same for online reviews?

*Survey ratings counts are much lower

Pain point relevance & multiple choice: how many users are affected?

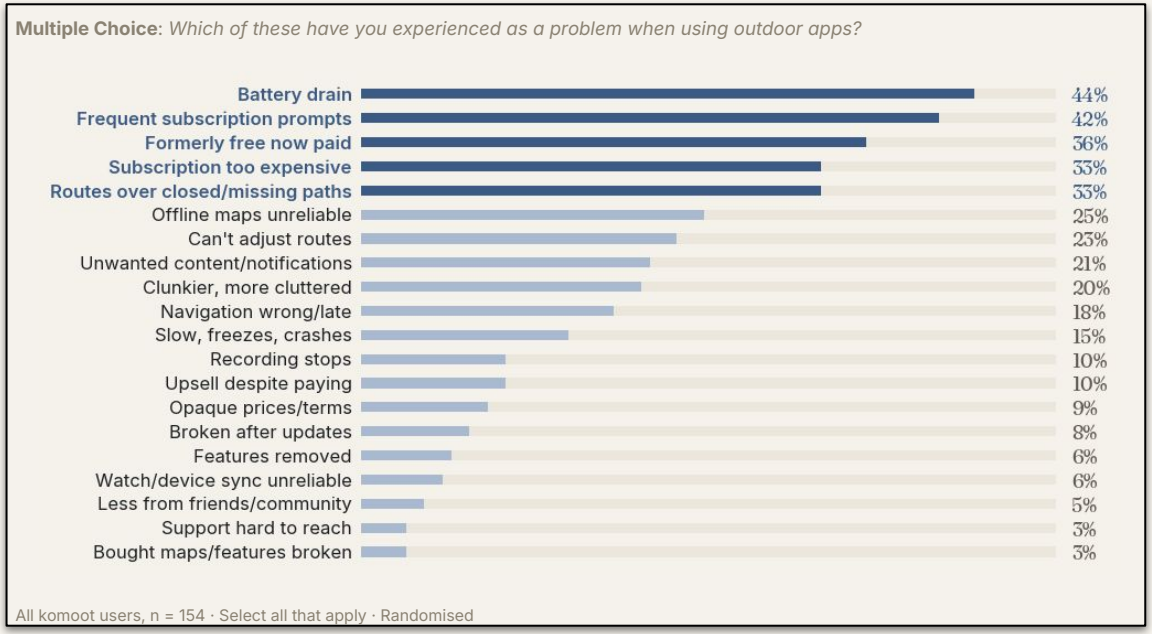
Although performance of the app and “Battery Drain” is the leading pain according to multiple choice, **3 of the top 5 are related to monetisation**

And the 3rd speaks directly to the acquisition: *“Formerly free, now paid”*

Ease in cognitive effort, pivoting from recall (reviews, open-ends) to recognition (multiple choice items)

But is it too easy?

“*oh, that one would also be really annoying too…”* - cognitive walkthrough participant

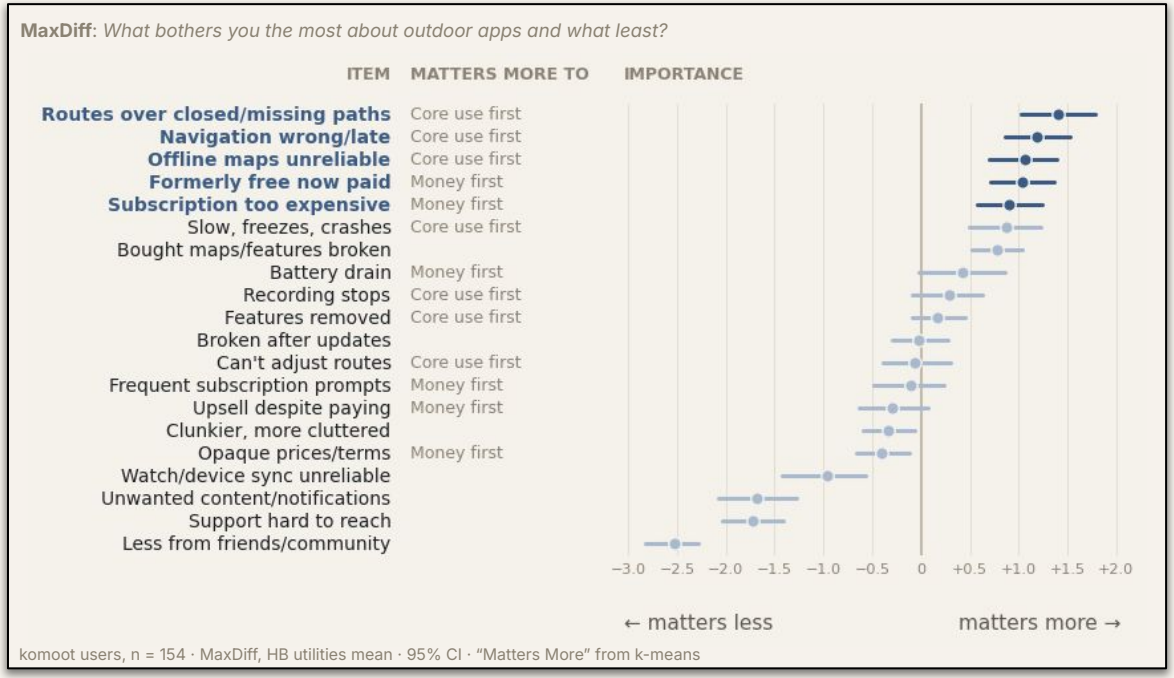


Most monetization is deprioritized when komoot users have to choose, but acquisition pain remains

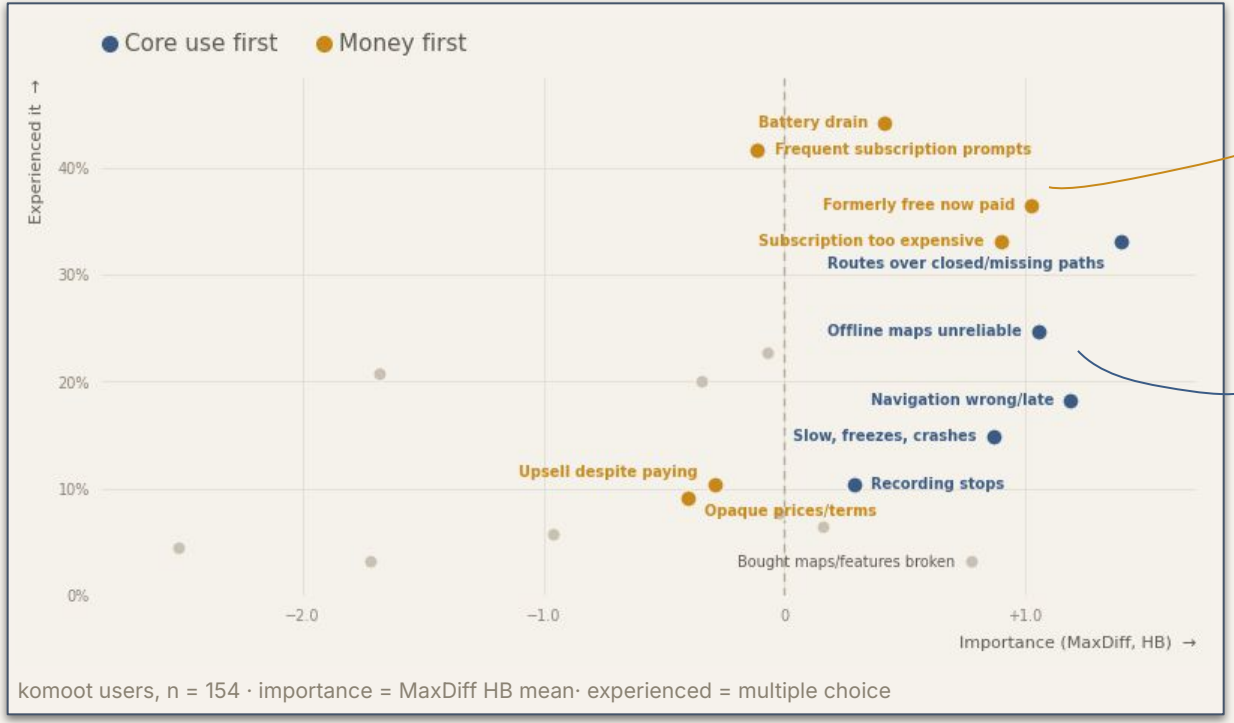
Product pains become most important after users need to make many trade offs

Where a “Core use first” cluster of responses differentiates from a “Money first” cluster

“Formerly Free, now paid” becomes an urgent pain, that arose directly from komoot’s acquisition



Core use problems reach higher importance, Money first problems may reach wider group



komoot users, n = 154 · importance = MaxDiff HB mean· experienced = multiple choice

Moderate pains with reach

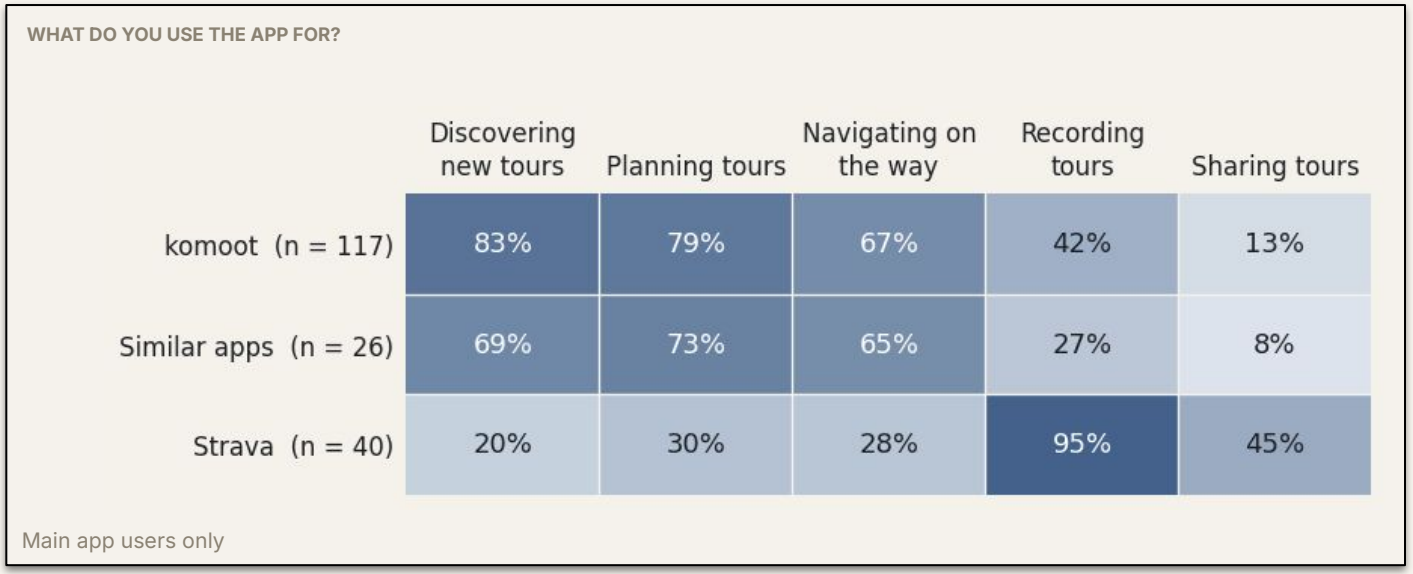
Resolving pains from “Money first cluster” may satisfy a larger share of users

Strong, precise pains

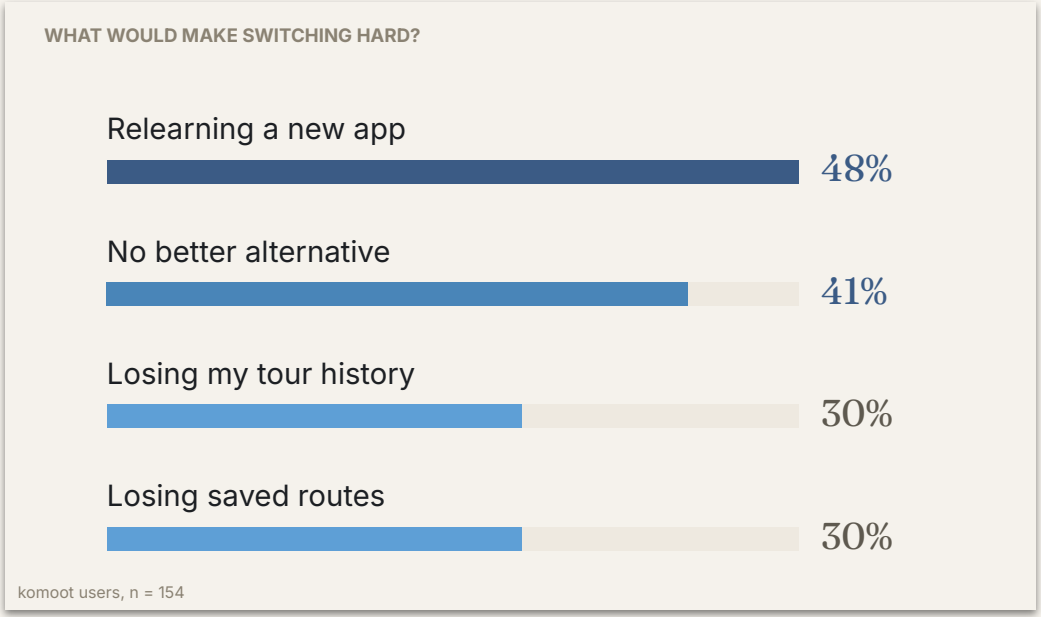
Most “Core use first” problems may seem niche, or just more precise

Routes over closed/missing paths is urgent with reach

komoot's job profile reflects other similar apps, showing less differentiation, higher risk of defection



komoot users would rather put effort into activity than switching to another app



85%

of komoot users are likely to continue

Yet the barriers to switch apps may be easy to break down

Bonus - Drivers of leaving:
1. Unreliable offline maps
2. Slow, freezes, crashes
3. Opaque prices / terms

To come to a close,



01

Acquisition Pain is Real

From product reviews to directly surveying users, **acquisition effects are detected among the pains that matter most**, through most stages, not just the online reviews.

02

Smarter with Context

Connecting the pains that matter most to user segments, barriers and near competitors **ground the results in the company's reality**, to help connect decisions with high-level strategy.

03

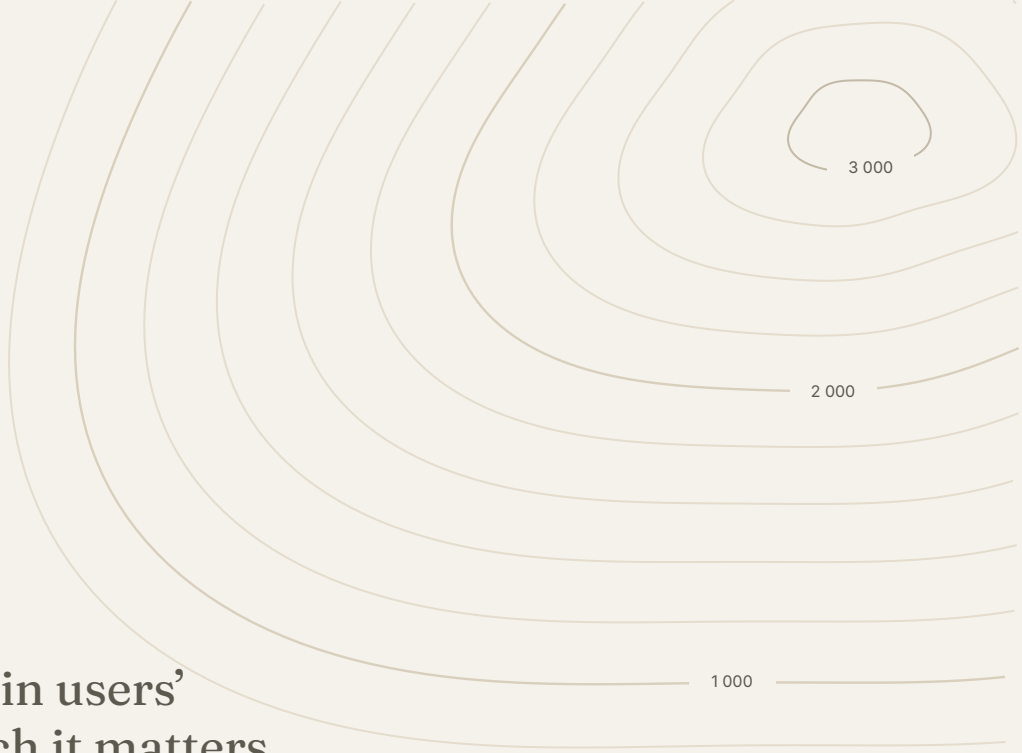
What's next?

The pipeline is already built. The focus now **expands from discovery of new pains to include monitoring performance** while problems are resolved; even with data from ratings & reviews can help here.

PART 3 · RELEVANCE

Decide

Classified text tells you *what* broke, in users' own words. Surveys tell us how much it matters.



Gaining higher ground with each instrument

MaxDiff

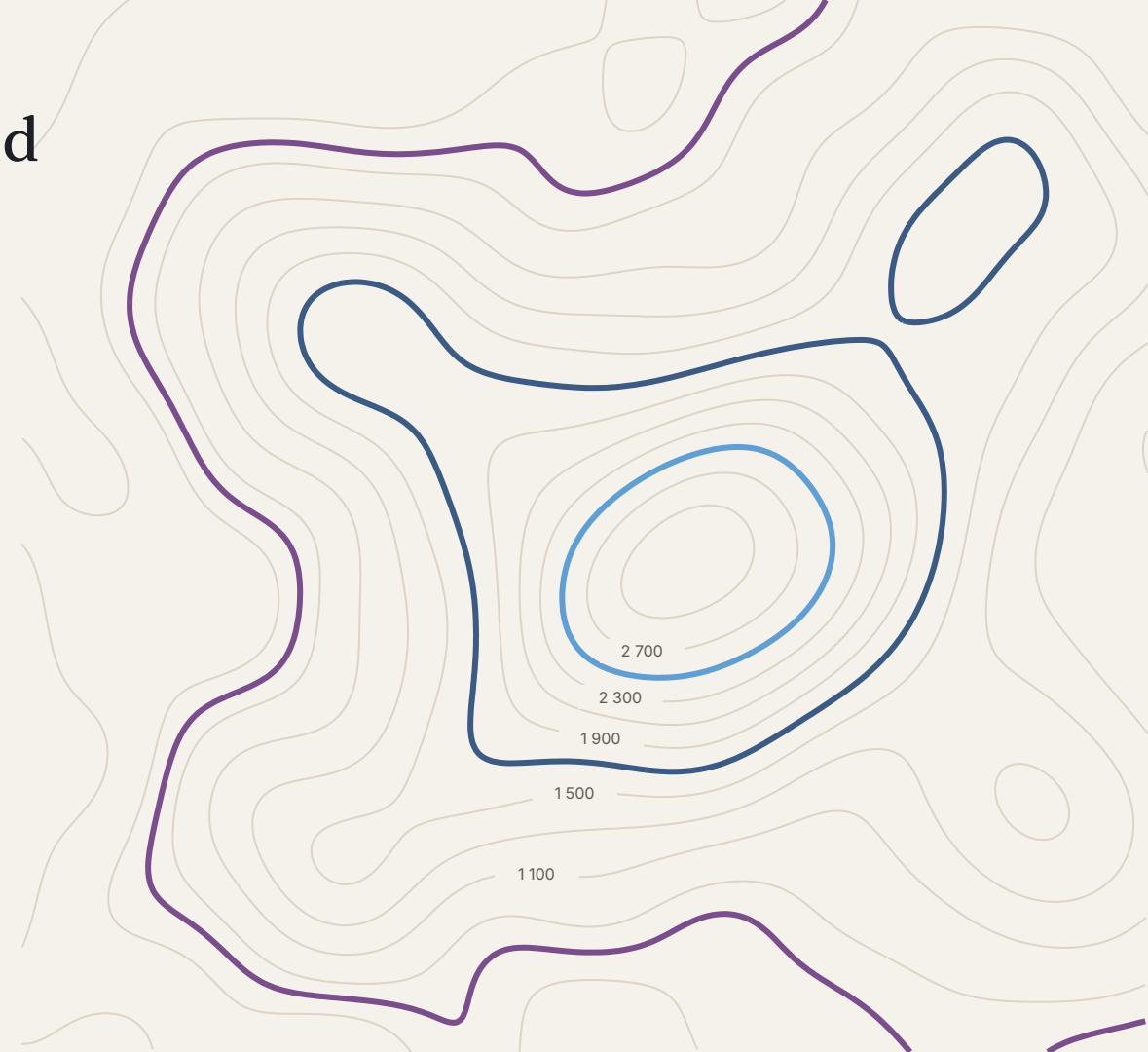
What matters most when people have to choose.

Multiple choice

How common each pain is, by recognition.

Reviews text analysis

What broke, in users' own words.



Which sizing method, when

METHOD	USE WHEN	MISLEADS WHEN
Frequency × rating impact	You have passive data on hand like reviews or open-ended text responses and a numeric value	The pain is quiet, or hard to communicate in recall format; self-selection bias
Key Driver Analysis	Regress numeric value on the pains present or on their likert results	Predictors are often correlated. Finds patterns but doesn't speak to what users would trade
Importance – Satisfaction	You need a gap to prioritise among known features	Everything is "important" and people use the scale differently.
MaxDiff	Pains must be traded off, and you need an absolute "not a problem" threshold.	The pain never made the list. Fatigue among casual users

If your user base shows signs of disruption,

will you beat your competitors to mining and sizing the pains to learn what matters most?

https://robertforrestheld.com/

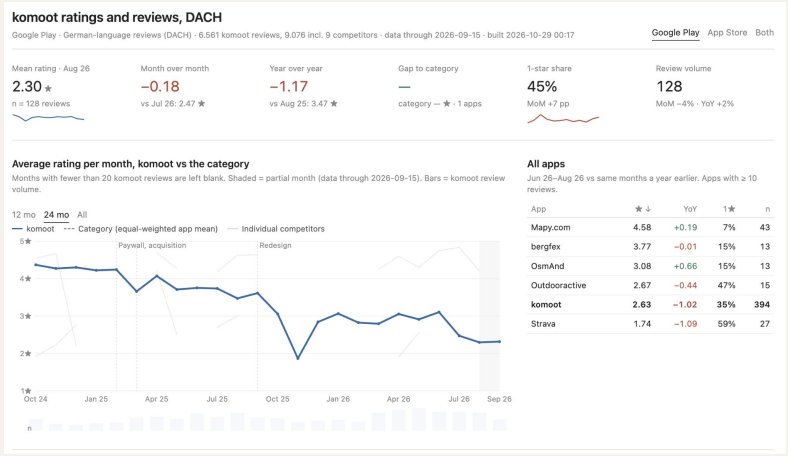


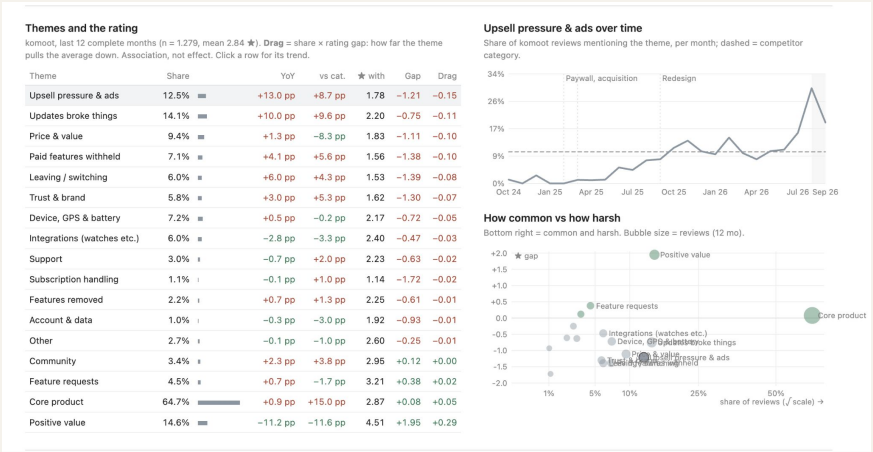
PART 2

Appendix

backups

Monitor Secondary Data with HTML dashboards





REVIEW TEXT

In their own words: from worry to walking away

MAR 2025 ★★★★★

„Hoffentlich wirkt sich der Verkauf an die Italiener nicht negativ aus.“

I hope the sale to the Italians doesn’t have a negative effect.

JUN 2025 ★☆☆☆☆

„Nach dem Verkauf an einen Investor und Rauswurf der meisten Mitarbeiter habe ich die App jetzt auch rausgeworfen.“

After the sale to an investor and most of the staff being thrown out, I’ve now thrown out the app too.

MAR 2026 ★☆☆☆☆

„Seit der Übernahme durch die neuen Besitzer ist die App eine Katastrophe … Werde mir überlegen, eine andere App zu nutzen.“

Since the takeover by the new owners the app is a disaster … I’ll think about using another app.

AUG 2026 ★★☆☆☆

„Enshittification! Ich habe lange Komoot sehr gerne genutzt … ständig Erinnerung zum Kauf des Premium Abos. Trotz des Welt Pakets …“

Enshittification! I liked komoot for a long time … constant reminders to buy Premium, despite having bought the world pack.

Google Play, German reviews of komoot · translations below each quote · quotes shortened where marked …

MaxDiff

Was stört Sie bei Outdoor-Apps am meisten – und was am wenigsten? (1/15)

Bitte wählen Sie in jeder Gruppe genau einen Punkt, der Sie am meisten stört, und einen, der Sie am wenigsten stört. Auch wenn Sie nicht alles selbst erlebt haben: Wählen Sie, was Sie am meisten und am wenigsten stören würde.

Am meisten		Am wenigsten
○	Bei Problemen ist es schwierig, Hilfe vom Support zu bekommen	○
○	Vorgeschlagene Routen führen über Wege, die gesperrt, unpassierbar oder nicht vorhanden sind	○
○	Die Bedienung der App ist umständlicher und unübersichtlicher geworden	○
○	Offline-Karten funktionieren auf Tour nicht zuverlässig	○

Zurück Weiter